Shivshankar Menon later noted, '[I]n the early 1990s it was hard to be nonaligned when there was no one to be aligned with or nonaligned against.' [6]

The conceptual confusion at the time about the state of international affairs was not restricted to India. Most thinkers and writers of international relations were also unsure how to navigate the post-Cold War world. For some, it was merely a unipolar moment, an opportunity for the enlargement and consolidation of a US-led international order. Inspired by the German philosopher G.W.F. Hegel, Francis Fukuyama argued that liberal democracy could mark the endpoint of man's ideological evolution: the 'End of History'. A belief even took hold in business and academic circles that the state would become increasingly irrelevant in international politics, giving way both to powerful supranational entities (such as the European Union) or non-state actors (such as multinational corporations). Others were more pessimistic. Samuel Huntington argued that the world would be characterized by a 'Clash of Civilizations,' and that the main global challenge could possibly be Islamist terrorism. Still others warned of American arrogance and overreach. Certain sceptics took this further and believed that the answer to many international problems lay in global disengagement by the United States. It was only a very small minority that argued consistently that the rise of new powers, particularly China, would result in a return of great power politics. In time, some of these predictions would prove partly vindicated—but only partly. [7]

Tentative Openings, 1991–1998

Amid the conceptual haze, a new post-Cold War world created ample new opportunities for policymakers. For India, a significant series of steps between 1991 and 1994 helped establish what became known as the Look East Policy. Initially, it served a primarily economic value. Rao sought investment and trade opportunities as he travelled to South Korea, Singapore and elsewhere in Southeast and Northeast Asia, but he also sought alternative economic models. New Delhi's efforts were initially